

4.4 Converters & Utilities

The lack of proper standards means that once you transfer your video files to another computer, you would have to make sure you carry all the necessary codecs along. This cumbersome task is put paid to if you manage to convert all your video files into one standard format. It also means you would need only a single player and a single codec to play back all your files. Also, with newer playback devices such as the PSP available, it would be prudent to have an application that can convert your media files into a format that can be played back on these devices.

A tool like a converter can come in handy when you want to create a DVD-type file from a normal AVI file. <Most converters are not freeware or shareware, and are available only for a specific trial period. In keeping with the mandate of this book, that of not dishing out trial software or demos, we have reviewed only those that are available for free and that are devoid of adware and watermarks on the output.

In addition to converters, tools that identify the codecs required to play a particular file and that give a list of the codecs on your computer are also available. These tools are generally created by individual programmers, and are prone to bugs and crashes. But the good part is they're free and open source, and hence undergo constant changes and improvement.

4.4.1 The FilmMachine

An AVI to DVD or VCD converter is a handy tool when you need to convert and burn home videos. This would also do away with the need to store videos in a bulky format on your computer, and you can convert them just before burning it onto CD or DVD.

The FilmMachine is a lightweight, free-to-use converter. It converts AVI files to DVD or (S)VCD files, and the wizard makes the task a cakewalk. The application lets you load more than one AVI file at a time; however, the properties of the two files need to be the same. It comes loaded with the QuEnc 0.51 video encoder.